MEAL financing gateway of 3%

Paper MEC-09, policy P3 of 7, for decision

Friday 20 November 2026, Session 3, 10:45–11:45 | Block B. Capability and financing | For decision

Draft of 4 November 2026 for TWG review. Parameters such as deadlines, response times and thresholds not set by the Framework are proposals, shown as such in the decision options.

The policy in brief

At least 3% of each budget centre's financed workplan budget goes to MEAL capabilities: visible in the workplan, tracked in expenditure and protected from reprogramming. New proposals budget MEAL at 3% or more.

Why this policy

Without financing, MEAL remains rhetorical. The Framework makes financing the gateway of the Minimum MEAL Package: an office that does not allocate and protect at least 3% of its resources for MEAL capabilities does not meet the floor, however well its other domains perform.

The threshold follows the Framework's reasoning: WHO governing bodies have recognized evaluation alone as warranting about 1% of resources, so 3% is a reasonable minimum for the whole system of monitoring, data, evaluation, analytics, learning, digital tools and capacity. Today MEAL is planned close to that level but financed far below it.

What the evidence shows

- In the 2026–2027 workplans, MEAL is **4.21% of planned costs** but **1.35% of financed costs**: **US$ 39.7 million** of MEAL is planned but not financed (provisional; paper MEC-08).
- MEAL cannot be tracked consistently today: workplans carry no common MEAL marker, so the figures above had to be reconstructed by analysis.

Scope

The workplans of the 47 Country Offices and the six Regional Office budget centres, all funding sources, and every proposal or award budget prepared by them.

The policy

1. **The gateway.** Each budget centre allocates at least 3% of its resources to MEAL capabilities. The Framework measures the 3% against programme resources and leaves the numerator, denominator, eligible costs and exclusions to Annex I. Until Annex I is issued, the MEC sets an interim rule (see options). The recommended rule measures the 3% against the financed workplan budget, meaning the funds available to the workplan as recorded in the corporate systems, and uses the eligible-cost list of Annex C, Section C4. Annex I, when issued, confirms or replaces the interim rule.
2. **What counts.** MEAL staffing, data management, P/S tracking and monitoring operations, data quality assessment and field verification, evaluations and strategic studies, analytics, dashboards and platform use, learning reviews and knowledge management, capacity strengthening, and accountability and feedback mechanisms. Ordinary programme costs are not reclassified as MEAL unless they demonstrably build MEAL capability.
3. **Visible.** Each workplan shows the MEAL allocation with a common MEAL marker in the SPM. For 2027, each budget centre records its current MEAL allocation with the marker by 31 March 2027; from the 2028–2029 workplans, the allocation is planned at 3% or more.
4. **Tracked.** Expenditure against the MEAL allocation is drawn from GSM and reported at each SAM cycle.

5. **Ring-fenced.** The MEAL allocation is ring-fenced from reprogramming (Annex A, 3.1). It may be moved between MEAL uses with the WR's documented approval, reported to MSC, but not to other purposes. A fall below 3% is a gateway failure: it raises the automatic gap flag of Annex C and is reported to the DPM.
6. **First calls on the 3%.** The allocation funds, first, the gaps to the floor in the office's development plan; a non-earmarked evaluation budget sufficient for at least one substantive evaluation per biennium (Annex A, 3.2; see P5); and data quality assessment and field monitoring (Annex A, 3.3).
7. **New proposals.** From 1 January 2027, every proposal and award budget includes MEAL costs of at least 3%, unless the donor's rules set otherwise. Exceptions are recorded with the reason.
8. **Transition and check.** A budget centre below 3% sets out in its development plan how it will reach the gateway in the 2028–2029 workplans. The gateway is checked at each annual Package review; failure raises the automatic gap flag of Annex C.

Who does what

WHO Representative or budget centre director	Accountable for the allocation and its ring-fencing; approves moves between MEAL uses.
Programme leads and external relations officers	Budget MEAL costs in workplans, proposals and award budgets.
Budget and finance officers	Apply the MEAL marker and extract expenditure from GSM.
MEAL focal point	Tracks the allocation and its use; reports at each SAM cycle.
MSC Unit and DPM	MSC issues the methodology and tracks MEAL financing across the Region; the DPM reports it to the MEC and acts on reductions below 3%.

Timeline

When	Milestone
1 Jan 2027	Proposal rule applies
31 Mar 2027	MEAL marker applied; current MEAL allocation recorded for every budget centre
SAM1 2027	First report of MEAL allocation and expenditure by budget centre
2027 planning cycle	MEAL planned at 3% or more in all 2028–2029 workplans
MEC 2027	Regional MEAL financing report

How compliance is measured

Indicator	Baseline	Target
MEAL share of financed workplan budget, Region	1.35% (provisional)	At least 3% in the 2028–2029 workplans
Budget centres at or above 3%	Not yet measured	All 53 in the 2028–2029 workplans
Proposals submitted with MEAL at 3% or more	Not yet measured	100% from 2027, exceptions recorded

Decision options

Option	What the MEC would adopt	Implications
A Recommended	**Interim rule: 3% of financed budget, all funding sources, with the proposal rule**	Protects MEAL where money actually arrives; most budget centres must raise their financed MEAL share, about 1.35% across the Region today.

Option	What the MEC would adopt	Implications
B	3% of planned cost	Already met on paper (4.21%), but leaves MEAL unfunded wherever plans are unfunded.
C	Interim rule: 3% of financed base budget only; emergency and polio funds follow the MEAL rules of their own appeals and plans	A smaller amount to find, but leaves the largest programmes without MEAL protected by this policy.

Resources

No new money: the policy re-directs 3% of financed budgets to MEAL. The proposal rule raises new MEAL funding over time.

The MEC is asked to

Adopt the 3% gateway, with the interim rule of 3% of financed budgets for all funding sources and the proposal rule (option A), until Annex I is issued.

Framework references: Framework Part VII.2; Annex A, Sub-dimensions 3.1 to 3.4; Annex B, Section B8; Annex C, Section C4; Annex I (not in this package). Domains: D3 MEAL financing (the gateway of the Minimum MEAL Package).